

format for streaming audio and video. WMA at 20 Kbps encoding quality is definitely comparable to MP3 at 64 Kbps. With higher bit rates, the audio sounds very crisp and smooth.

With the abundance of streaming audio on the Internet leading to a large number of me-too radio stations, the quibbles over licence fees for using formats have only just started. Some stations prefer to use their own proprietary streaming formats; still others depend on underlying RealNetworks or Windows Media streaming technology, but use their own player interface. Among the notable proprietary options is Spinner, which offers you over 175 stations to choose from. Spinner has now tied up with Netscape, and the service is called Radio@Netscape Plus (www.spinner.com). You need to install the Radio@Netscape Plus player to get connected to their vast collection of stations.

Shoutcast Radio

Shoutcast radio (www.shoutcast.com) is brought to you by Nullsoft, the folks behind Winamp. Shoutcast is more than just a streaming system. For hardcore radiophiles, it is a way of life. It streams out music in the MP3 format, so all you require is any standard MP3 player. With Shoutcast giving broadcasters all the tools they need for free, enthusiasts from all over the wired world have set up their own radio stations. Tuning in and listening is easy—just pick up a radio station that plays your favourite music and groove to the beat.

Since all you need to transmit using

Jargon Buster

DMCA: Short for the Digital Millennium Copyright Act, which protects and upholds US copyright laws in digital media.

Encoding quality: This is the measure of the quality of the encoded (compressed) audio. It is measured in Kbps (kilo bits per second) and higher values indicate a better encoding quality.

RIAA: Short for the Recording Industry Association Of America, it is the main music industry lobby group within the USA.

Streaming media: The media (audio/visual) is not conventionally downloaded before playback, instead it is continuously streamed from the Internet and cached locally before it is displayed.

Streaming Technology that Needs Broadband

Well, if radio can get this good, then video has got to be better. In many parts of the wired world, people are logging on to view Web TV. It's true. It's happening. But you need a broadband connection. And no, cable Internet access (at least by Indian standards) just won't do—try getting hold of a DSL line that gives you 384 Kbps access or greater.

Here's what you can expect: entire TV shows, encoded at good quality and movies, both online and offline. In the US, you can currently logon to MovieLink at

www.movielink.com and legitimately purchase and download a movie for as little as \$2.95 (around Rs 150). This is not a low-grade knock-off copy—you are sold a high-quality print. Of course, there are controls embedded into the movie to limit the usage and spread. You can also catch live sports broadcasts at places such as Willow TV (www.willow.tv) that screens entire cricket matches in good quality video over broadband. Oh yes, you will never miss the news with nearly all big news channels carrying their broadband Web-casts.



Shoutcast: broadcasting to your home

Shoutcast is bandwidth, loads of songs and a couple of Winamp plugins, it has become enormously popular with small time independent broadcasters, as well as those who would like to host a radio station over a LAN. This offers you the radio equivalent of the Swiss Army Knife when it comes to content. All Shoutcast Internet broadcasters can list their radio stations at Shoutcast's Web site, so you can search through radio stations right there. The radio stations can choose the bit rates for the stream quality, so pick up a radio station that delivers good quality and doesn't hog your bandwidth—if you choose a bit rate of 64 kbps or lower, the stream of audio sounds good even over a dialup connection.

You now have the tools and the know-how, so let's tune in to some great stations.

Tune in

If you are listening to one of the stations that broadcast using a proprietary player, the easiest way to locate a station of your choice will be using the player itself. Radio@Netscape Plus for example, lets you select the genre and station straight from the player. The quality of the audio is really good and you get to choose from

175 niche channels across the board. With such services, you do have to put up with the advertisements, but in Radio@Netscape Plus they occupy an unobtrusive corner of the player.

To explore and go beyond the beaten path, you need a radio station guide. One of the best we recommend is the guide at RadioTower (www.radiotower.com). This station guide offers you a huge selection of stations located across 80 countries and over 20 different genres. You can pick up stations that transmit in Real Audio and WMA formats. The lower bit rate stations sound very clear with WMA—definitely recommended for modem users.

Live365 (www.live365.com) is the granddaddy of all streaming sites and claims to be the world's largest Internet radio network. You can choose between



RadioTower: towering over the rest

downloading the proprietary player and using your existing one. Other than this, be sure to check out Shoutcast—it has close to 3,000 radio stations neatly sorted by genre and bit rate. With the sheer number of stations available, it's easy to access a fast server. An old dependable site is the RealNetworks's RealOne Guide, (www.home.real.com) that lets you choose from a variety of streaming entertainment in Real format.